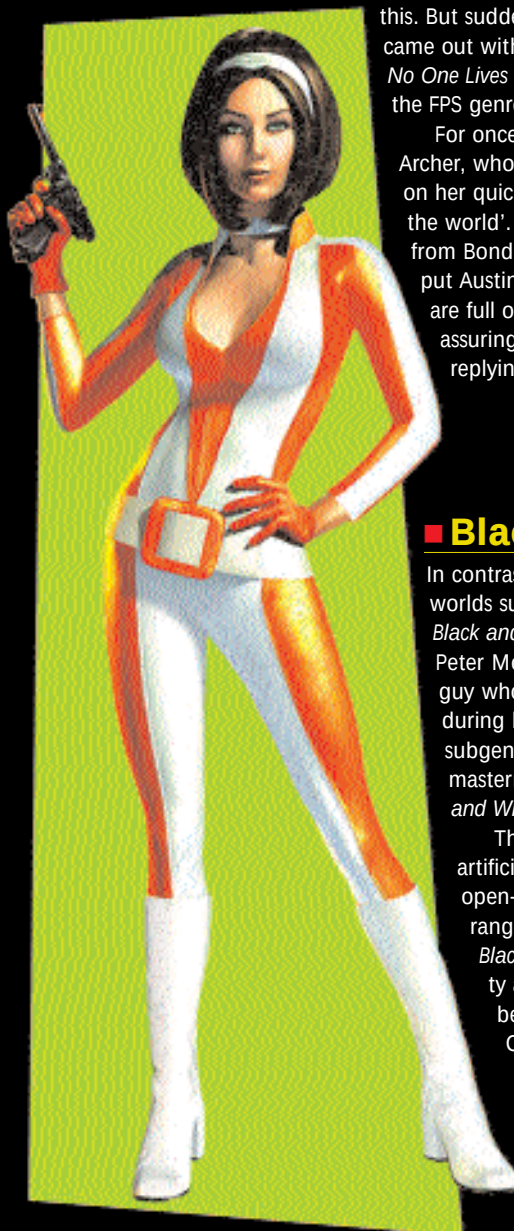




15 essentials for a die hard gamer

Enthralling scenarios,
mind-blowing graphics,
fast-paced action and
thrills that have kept us
glued to our PC!
Games that have
inspired us,
scared us, and
amazed us.
Here's a count down of
games that no gamer
worth his salt should miss.
Want to play?



■ Deus Ex

Conspiracy theories, global domination, secret service and a few chosen who rule the world. That's the background for ION Storm's FPS/RPG, *Deus Ex*. (FPS: First Person Shooter, RPG Role Playing Game). The role-playing element in *Deus Ex* comes primarily from skills and augmentations, which makes the game very interesting. Want rock solid aim with the sniper rifle? Invest your points in the rifles skill. Want to make it easier to pick locks or hack computers? Invest in lock-picking and computers, respectively. The choices you make in skill distribution directly affect your performance in the game.

■ No One Lives Forever

Monolith never had a track record of making good games before this. But suddenly, almost out of nowhere, they came out with a kitschy, 1960s-Bond-themed *No One Lives Forever* (NOLF), which rejuvenated the FPS genre itself.

For once, there's a female lead, Cate Archer, who doesn't rely on her 'assets' but on her quick wit and quicker reflexes to 'save the world'. The game uses several clichés from Bond movies with humour that would put Austin Powers to shame. The cut-scenes are full of one-liners, like Archer's partner assuring her, "I can be subtle," and Cate replying, "Then explain that shirt."

■ Black and White

In contrast to the traditionally violent game worlds such as *Quake* and *Soldier of Fortune*, *Black and White* is almost a work of art. Peter Molyneux is a British scallywag—a guy who re-reads *Lord of the Rings* during his free time. He's the creator of a subgenre called the 'God game' and is the mastermind behind *Populous* and *Black and White*.

The game has an insanely complex artificial intelligence (AI) and offers an open-ended gameplay with a limitless range of emotional and moral paths. *Black and White* stands apart in creativity and perhaps even surpasses our best films or books on that count. Call it interactive art, this game changes itself as you play it, and over a period of time, it becomes a reflection of who you really are.